magnitude of daily decisions, which are second guessed by people with minimal knowledge of the situation.

It's like a football manager walking into a changing room to address his players for the first time. He must meet questioning eyes. He knows what is going on behind those eyes. Every player is watching intently and wondering what change will mean for him. Ultimately words are of secondary importance to actions.

When I took the job, I had a short but significant exchange with Andy.

'What kind of captain do you want to be?' he asked me.

'I want to be an honest captain.'

'Honest?'

'Yeah. You've got to be honest.'

'Well, what happens if you drop a player. Are you going to be honest then?'

'Yeah, yeah. I'll tell the truth.'

'So. You're going to drop this player because he isn't bowling well, or he can't hit it off the square. You're going to tell him, in so many words, that you can't trust him.'

'I'm not sure if I'd say that.'

'But what happens if there's an injury, and you need that player for the next Test match? You've just told him you don't trust him, because you're honest.'

He had a point.

It was a crash course in the value of relationships, which become more interdependent on tour, when captain and coach pick the team. A selector is normally on hand, in case you don't agree, but there is a constant need to manage, firmly but sensitively, the five or six players who are on the outside, looking in.

It involves straddling the age-old credibility gap between practice and theory. You must be truthful, because otherwise they won't respect your authority. You can't tell lies, because they will come back and bite you on the arse. But the truth, the whole truth and nothing but the truth? You learn quickly that idealism is a luxury.

Dealing with disappointment is the hardest part of the job. My compromise was to have what I used to call the toilet chat, a private conversation away from prying eyes and ears. I always offered the dropped player the option of revisiting the conversation, though not many took up